

Light Enough For Flight

Agent001 recounts his laptop buying experiences

In the last two years the personal technology space has seen tremendous growth both in terms of demand and in terms of variety. It pleases me greatly to see folks actually taking the time and patience to learn about the product they want to purchase, instead of blindly making an uninformed purchase decision. Besides cell phones, PDAs and PMPs, if I were to pick one product category that is hot, it'd have to be laptops. Many queries directed to me are from readers who wish to buy a notebook for a certain purpose, or based on a particular configuration. Students want something on a frugal budget that allows them to complete their assignments, surf the Internet, and take notes during lectures. Engineers want a configuration that will allow them to run Visual Studio, or Java, and surf the Internet, or even play the odd game. Others may have specific requirements—like a good integrated webcam to chat with loved ones abroad, or a notebook that plays 3D games with most of the bells and whistles enabled. A large bunch of users are confused as to whether to even buy a notebook or opt for a desktop PC instead. Their confusion is understandable—a decent desktop PC can be assembled for Rs 25,000 or thereabouts, which is the same price at which you can pick up and entry level notebook. Users are even willing to up their budgets and pay more for a notebook, their reason, notebooks are

more of a lifestyle symbol (if not a status symbol), and they're portable. It's cool to be seen with a notebook, and the whole image of notebooks being expensive, drool-worthy devices takes your status to a whole new high. Even though laptops are common nowadays they're still viewed as a novelty by most people and this is one of the main factors behind their speedy adoption. Of course it's a much needed tool for the business and executive cadre of user.

Regarding the whole desktop vs. notebook argument, I'm a firm believer in both devices. For me a notebook is a necessity when computing on the move, or attending a press conference to take down notes, or to communicate with office folk and access mails and such when a PC is unavailable. But when I have my desktop PC in front of me—my notebook is forgotten. Both devices are meant to co-exist peacefully, and home users should actually see whether they really need the portability of a notebook before buying one. In terms of performance and ergonomics, a desktop is at least two times the performance of a notebook, my suggestion is to buy a notebook only if you need portable computing. For someone who intends to use his computer on his desk every night after

coming home from office, a notebook PC is a total waste—a desktop is much better suited for such tasks. I also recommend you skip the notion of buying a notebook just to be cool—it's ludicrous.

A so called gaming notebook needs a fast graphics card, and implementing such a graphics solutions into a notebook, where heat dissipation and product size are significant factors, is expensive—Rs 75,000 at least. I do not consider Dell's XPS 1530 to be a gaming notebook—for one, the NVIDIA GeForce 8600GT video solution in this notebook is strictly a low-end solution.

There's a lot of confusion when it comes to notebook components, and visits around the various electronics malls around Mumbai left me with one impression—a lot has to be done to educate consumers. Posing as a newbie I was surprised to see some misleading tactics used by even large vendors. For example a notebook with an NVIDIA GeForce motherboard (GeForce 6150 chipset) had a bold sticker saying "NVIDIA graphics". True, but to most users "NVIDIA graphics" or "Graphics by ATI" means an additional graphics card—whereas this notebook had just an integrated graphics chip. This was an issue with notebooks with ATI onboard solutions as well, and users wanting a graphics card should look for a sticker with the name of the graphics solution mentioned on it like GeForce 8400GS or Radeon X2400 Pro. Most of the sales reps cannot help you either—and they'll expound on the hard disk size, and choice of OS bundled when asked about differences between two similar looking notebooks, instead of talking about processors and memory. A notebook is a

solution, not something you build like a PC, and considering that even I got misled at one point, its imaginable how

first time buyers often get duped—whether intentionally or unintentionally on the part of the vendor. When looking at models, it's important to get a hands-on feel, after all you need to use the device regu-



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